Coherence of Resilience Measures for the Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation Across a Hierarchy of Models

Andreas Morr[1,2*] Reyk Börner[3] Sjoerd Terpstra[3]

Christian Kuehn[1]

October 16, 2026

Abstract

The Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation (AMOC) is a critical component of the global climate system, and its potential collapse one of the most consequential climate tipping events. Quantifying AMOC resilience, that is, its capacity to maintain the active circulation state under external perturbations, is therefore of high scientific and societal importance. Resilience is a multifaceted concept, encompassing many notions of transient system response. Whether these distinct measures yield consistent, and therefore trustworthy, signals across models of different complexity has not been systematically examined. Here, we address this question by analysing four models that span a hierarchy in physical complexity: (i) a 3-box salinity model, (ii) a two-dimensional latitude-depth Boussinesq model of the overturning circulation, (iii) the Earth system model of intermediate complexity CLIMBER-X, and (iv) the general circulation model PlaSim-LSG. Across the hierarchy, we compute model-specific implementations of four complementary resilience concepts: local resilience, convergence time, basin volume, and minimal critical shock. Our results suggest that not all measures are coherent across the

*Corresponding author: andreas.morr@tum.de

model hierarchy, as exhibited by incompatible trends under increasing CO_2 forcing in each model. This points to deficiencies in model compatibility and challenges in applying these concepts in real-world systems. Several measures indicate an unexpected increase in system resilience under climate change. These findings have direct implications for the detectability of an imminent AMOC collapse from observational or model-based early-warning signals.

Keywords: Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation, tipping points, resilience, model hierarchy

1 Introduction

The Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation is one of the dominant features of the Earth's oceans, transporting large amounts of warm, saline surface waters northward across the Atlantic and returning cold, deep North Atlantic water southward at depth (**??**). This large-scale transport pattern underpins the relatively mild climate of Western Europe and plays a central role in the global carbon and heat cycles (**???**). Palaeoclimate records document repeated rapid transitions between an active (AMOC-on) and a weakened or collapsed (AMOC-off) state during the Pleistocene, associated with Dansgaard–Oeschger events (**???**). Under continued anthropogenic forcing, rising sea surface temperatures, freshening of the North Atlantic from increased precipitation, and Greenland ice-sheet melt may push the AMOC towards a similar transition (**????**).

More concretely, in background climate configurations where at least two stable equilibria coexist (the on and off states), the system can be permanently tipped from one to the other by crossing a critical threshold leading to the annihilation of one of the formerly stable states (bifurcation-induced tipping) or by a sufficiently large state perturbation (shock-induced tipping) (Ashwin et al., 2012; Alkhayuon et al., 2019). Rate-induced tipping is another pathway, though it will not be relevant for this work. In the bifurcation-theory framework for AMOC tipping, the transition to the off state is often conceptualised as a saddle-node bifurcation (van Westen et al., 2025). A shock-induced transition, on the other hand, can be understood as an exit of the system state from the basin of attraction associated with the AMOC on state. In both frameworks, the AMOC is investigated as an autonomous dynamical system that may be influenced by slow parameter changes or external perturbations, such as noise. This allows for the characterisation of the system in terms of several quantities, subsumed under the term "resilience" (Krakovská et al., 2024).

One important notion of resilience has been applied to the AMOC in the context of a bifurcation-induced transition. As the system approaches such a transition through a gradual change in the background climate, the stable on-state loses linear stability, a phenomenon known as critical slowing down (CSD) (Scheffer et al., 2009). CSD manifests

in observable statistics: near the bifurcation, the dominant eigenvalue of the linearised system approaches zero, leading to increases in variance and autocorrelation of system fluctuations (Held and Kleinen, 2004; Dakos et al., 2008). These generic signatures have motivated a large body of research on early-warning indicators of tipping (Lenton, 2011; Boers, 2021; Ditlevsen and Ditlevsen, 2023).

Yet CSD-based indicators capture only the system's reaction to small perturbations around the equilibrium, known as local resilience, quantifying how the on-state changes locally as the bifurcation is approached. A complementary perspective is provided by non-local resilience concepts, which characterise the size and geometry of the basin of attraction of the on-state and therefore also capture the system's capacity to recover from larger perturbations (Holling, 1973; Gunderson, 2000; Menck et al., 2013). A comprehensive assessment of the resilience of the AMOC on state should encompass many different notions. In this work, we consider four resilience measures with the following heuristic definitions and interpretations. The concrete implementation and calculations for each model will vary and are explained in Section 2.

1. **Local resilience**: capacity of a system to continuously absorb small perturbations to its equilibium on-state, such as noise and internal variability (Arnoldi et al., 2016).

2. **Convergence time**: duration trajectories take to return to the on-state equilibrium after a large perturbation (Neubert and Caswell, 1997).

3. **Basin volume**: the volume fraction of a reference region of initial model conditions that converges to the on-state (Menck et al., 2013).

4. **Minimal critical shock**: the smallest instantaneous perturbation that moves the system out of the basin of attraction of the on-state (Klinshov et al., 2015; Halekotte and Feudel, 2020).

In natural systems, controlled perturbation experiments are rarely feasible, making direct estimation of non-local resilience quantities from observations difficult. This is es-

pecially true for the AMOC, and numerical models, therefore, play an essential role. However, climate models span an enormous range of complexity, from analytically tractable conceptual models to full Earth system models (ESMs). It is not obvious whether resilience measures computed in simple models translate to their more complex counterparts, which include many additional feedbacks and degrees of freedom (Stouffer et al., 2006; Schneider et al., 2017). If measures disagree across the hierarchy, it could mean that parts of the hierarchy do not expose them well. The extrapolation of findings from simple models to more complex ones, or to the real-world system, is then harder to justify. Several studies have examined individual resilience concepts in the context of the AMOC at specific levels of model complexity (Rahmstorf et al., 2005; Cimatoribus et al., 2014; Boers, 2021; Ditlevsen and Ditlevsen, 2023; Jacques-Dumas et al., 2024), but a systematic, multi-measure comparison across a model hierarchy is lacking.

Our analysis combines four modelling studies that span many orders of magnitude of model complexity: (i) a conceptual 3-box salinity model (Wood et al., 2019; Alkhayuon et al., 2019), (ii) a latitude-depth Boussinesq partial differential equation model (**??**Esclapez et al., 2026), (iii) the Earth system model of intermediate complexity CLIMBER-X (Willeit et al., 2022), and (iv) the coupled general circulation model PlaSim-LSG (Börner et al., 2026). Section 2 describes each model and the concrete resilience measures computed for it. Section 3 reports the individual model's results and Section 4 synthesises them across the hierarchy. In Section 4, we discuss implications for research on the AMOC and on early-warning detection of potential tipping.

2 Methods

We compute a common set of resilience measures for each model while respecting the different experimental possibilities at different levels of the hierarchy. More concretely, we analyse trajectories from perturbed initial conditions. The reduced state space in which perturbations and convergence are investigated is defined by North Atlantic and Tropical Atlantic salinity values. Salt is conserved by applying a compensating perturbation in the remaining parts of the world ocean. Figure 1 illustrates the model-specific perturbation

and diagnostic regions, and their implementation is explained in the respective subsections below. Table 1 gives an overview of the concrete meaning and estimation routine for each resilience measure across the models. Initial conditions in the 3-box, Boussinesq, and CLIMBER-X experiments are probed within rectangles bounded by ± 2 psu perturbations relative to their model-specific reference configurations. This is done by drawing a large number of uniform samples from this region (3-box model) or by evenly sampling a grid of initial conditions (Boussinesq model and CLIMBER-X). PlaSim-LSG is an exception here, since we analyse existing edge-track and equilibrium runs from Börner et al. (2026) using two salinity readouts in the North and Tropical Atlantic.

We repeat the resilience analysis across a global-warming forcing coordinate, as specified for each model below. This allows us to compare directional trends of resilience, which are more meaningful across models than absolute values expressed in model-specific units. The resilience of the AMOC on-state is the primary focus throughout, though all analyses could also be carried out for other equilibria when present.

2.1 3-Box salinity model

We adopt the 5-box salinity model introduced by Wood et al. (2019) and further reduced to 3 boxes by Alkhayuon et al. (2019). The original model partitions the Atlantic–Indo-Pacific basin into five boxes: North Atlantic (N), Tropical Atlantic (T), Southern Ocean (S), Indo-Pacific (IP), and a Deep box (B). In the implemented 3-box reduction, the North and Tropical Atlantic salinity anomalies, S_N and S_T, are the two dynamical state variables. The slow variables of Southern Ocean and Deep-box salinities are prescribed as constants by the parameter vector, while Indo-Pacific salinity is derived at each time from salt conservation. The exact model equations and parameters are given in the Supplementary Information.

Wood et al. (2019) calibrated two distinct parameter sets for the model: one for a pre-industrial climate ($p_{1\times}$) and one for a doubled-CO_2 climate ($p_{2\times}$) in the FAMOUS Earth System model. We construct a continuum of models through the full parameter vector as $p(r) = p_{1\times} + r(p_{2\times} - p_{1\times})$ and label it by $C(r) = 280\,\mathrm{ppm} + 280\,\mathrm{ppm}\,r$. Thus

Table 1: **Overview of resilience-measure implementations across the model hierarchy.**

	3-Box model	**Boussinesq**	**CLIMBER-X**	**PlaSim-LSG**
AMOC strength	Overturning flux q at the on-state fixed point (see SI).	Streamfunction mean over a fixed northern interior window of the on-state equilibrium.	Maximum of the Atlantic overturning streamfunction at 26°N; trailing 500-year mean of the equilibrium run.	Maximum of the Atlantic overturning streamfunction between 46° and 66°N; mean over the on-state equilibrium run.
Local resilience	$-\mathrm{Re}(\lambda_{\max})$: negative real part of the least stable eigenvalue of the Jacobian at the on-state fixed point, evaluated via forward-mode automatic differentiation (Khan and Barton, 2015).	$-\mathrm{Re}(\lambda_{\max})$: negative real part of the least stable eigenvalue fitted from a 2×2 discrete linear map via isotropic salinity perturbations.	$-\mathrm{Re}(\lambda_{\max})$: negative real part of the least stable eigenvalue fitted from a 2×2 discrete linear map via isotropic salinity perturbations.	Inverse of the long axis of the on-state fluctuation cloud ellipse.
Convergence time	Mean return time of on-state trajectories among 10 000 uniform random initial conditions in a ±2 psu box; convergence at $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu proximity.	Mean return time of valid on-state trajectories on a 20×20 grid over ±2 psu; convergence at $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu proximity.	Mean return time of completed trajectories on a 9×9 grid over ±2 psu; convergence defined by permanent entry into an $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu ball.	Mean transit time from the last edge-state 4σ ellipse visit to the first on-state 4σ ellipse entry.
Basin volume	Fraction of 10 000 random initial conditions in a ±2 psu box centred on the on state that converge to the on state.	Fraction of valid initial conditions on the 20×20 perturbation grid converging to the on state.	Fraction of the 9×9 grid initial conditions over ±2 psu that converge back to the reference equilibrium (permanent entry into an $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu ball).	Not estimated because the available edge tracks do not thoroughly sample a reference region of state space.
Minimal critical shock	Minimum salinity-plane distance from the on state to a sampled initial condition not converging to the on state.	Minimum salinity-plane distance from the on state to a sampled initial condition not converging to the on state.	Minimum salinity-plane distance from the on-state to a sampled initial condition not converging to the on state.	Gap between the on-state and edge-state 4σ Gaussian ellipses along the line joining their centres in the deep-box salinity plane.

$r = 0$ and $r = 1$ correspond to 280 and 560 ppm, respectively, while $r > 1$ denotes linear extrapolation beyond the doubled-CO_2 parameter vector. The nominal spacing is $\Delta r = 0.05$, or 14 ppm, and we investigate the system from 280 through 896 ppm, with one additional point at 903 ppm ($r = 2.225$). We find that the on-state vanishes in a bifurcation when extrapolating the linear parameter ramp further, between 903 and 910 ppm.

All numerical experiments and resilience calculations are performed using the Julia package Attractors.jl (Datseris et al., 2023) within the DynamicalSystems.jl ecosystem. This computational framework enables efficient integration of large initial-condition ensembles and simultaneous tracking of multiple resilience measures as a parameter changes (Morr et al., 2026). At each continuation step, we probe the two-dimensional state space with 10 000 initial conditions sampled uniformly from a ± 2 psu rectangle centred on the on-state attractor. From these, we derive basin volume as the fraction of trajectories converging to the on state, the minimal critical shock as the minimum distance of the on state to an initial condition outside the basin, and convergence time as the mean time to reach a 0.05 psu neighbourhood. Local resilience is computed from the numerically derived Jacobian of the model's right-hand side at the on-state position. The resilience is measured as $-\mathrm{Re}(\lambda_{\max})$ where $\lambda_{\max}$ is the eigenvalue with the largest real part. In Figure 2, we map out the local basin geometry on a regular grid and show several example trajectories in terms of AMOC strength and phase-space evolution.

2.2 Boussinesq latitude-depth model

The second model in our hierarchy is a latitude-depth Boussinesq model of the AMOC. The model evolves temperature, salinity, streamfunction, and vorticity on a 21×41 grid of discretised latitude and depth points. The one-dimensional sea surface is forced by cosine profiles of temperature and salinity flux, with lower temperatures and lower net freshwater input at high latitudes. This model is much less expensive than global circulation models but already contains spatially structured salinity fields and overturning, making it a useful intermediate step between the conceptual box model and the three-dimensional climate

models.

We introduce a single external forcing parameter that mimics Arctic amplification. Increasing it flattens the equator-to-pole surface temperature profile (Arctic amplification) and enhances the freshwater forcing profile (intensification of the hydrological cycle). For the exact mechanism of this parameter, its mapping to CO_2, and the exact model equations, consult the Supplementary Information. The perturbation experiments are performed across seven forcing values corresponding to CO_2 concentrations from 280 ppm to approximately 643 ppm. For each configuration, the model is first spun up twice under weak hemispheric salinity-forcing asymmetries to ensure convergence to the on- and off-states, respectively. Under the symmetric salinity forcing, for which an active and a reversed overturning state can coexist over part of the forcing range, we obtain the final AMOC on and off reference states by evolving the asymmetric-forcing equilibria until convergence. Based on the reference on-state, we initialise perturbed salinity trajectories. We then classify each perturbed run by the reference state it settles to, which in turn enables the basin-volume, minimal critical shock, and convergence-time measures.

Initial-condition perturbations are applied to grid-aligned salinity boxes, and we define an affine conversion of the non-dimensional salinity units of the Boussinesq model to psu (for details see Supplementary Information). The North Atlantic box covers 40.5°–90°N, the Tropical Atlantic box covers 31.5°S–40.5°N, and the Southern compensation box covers the domain south of 31.5°S. All three extend approximately through the upper third of the water column. The perturbation fields are cosine-tapered to avoid sharp salinity gradients. Perturbations are applied as salinity anomalies $(\Delta S_N, \Delta S_T)$ on a 20×20 grid (400 initial conditions), with both amplitudes spanning ± 2 psu relative to the asymmetric-forcing on-state equilibrium, which lies within 0.1 psu of the final on-state. A compensating perturbation in the Southern box conserves total domain salinity.

For the basin-mapping ensemble, only the salinity field of the on-state equilibrium is carried over into the perturbed initial conditions. The temperature, vorticity, and streamfunction fields are set to zero and left to re-adjust to the perturbed salinity under the model dynamics. This isolates the salinity perturbation as the driver of the response.

To estimate local linear stability, we run a second, smaller ensemble of eight experiments per forcing level. Each run has a salinity perturbation in the two-dimensional (North and Tropical Atlantic) salinity space. The eight perturbations are evenly arranged on a circle of radius $\varepsilon = 0.5$ psu around the on-state equilibrium. Unlike the basin-mapping ensemble, these perturbations are applied to the complete equilibrium state, retaining all temperature, vorticity, and streamfunction fields, so that the local recovery of the full system is reflected in the two-dimensional salinity projection. All trajectories are run under neutral symmetric salinity forcing for approximately 500 model years. After discarding an initial ≈50-year transient, a 2×2 discrete linear map M is fitted by least squares to trajectory pairs $(x_t, x_{t+\Delta t})$ sampled every ≈20 years, where $x = (\delta S_N, \delta S_T)$ denotes the box-salinity deviation from equilibrium. The continuous-time generator $A = \log(M)/\Delta t$ of the fitted map M yields eigenvalues whose least stable real part gives the local resilience $-\mathrm{Re}(\lambda_{\max})$.

Time metrics are reported on a year-proxy scale, set to 100 times the arbitrary model time unit, to facilitate comparability across illustrations. In Figure 3, we plot four exemplary trajectories in terms of the two box salinities and the AMOC strength at 280 ppm and approximately 488 ppm.

2.3 CLIMBER-X

CLIMBER-X (Willeit et al., 2022) is a fast Earth system model of intermediate complexity (EMIC) that couples a 3-D frictional-geostrophic ocean model, a 2.5-D statistical-dynamical atmosphere, a dynamic-thermodynamic sea-ice model, and land-surface components. The ocean component resolves the full three-dimensional salinity and temperature fields, including the main overturning circulation cells, at a resolution of approximately $5^\circ \times 5^\circ$ with 23 vertical levels. CLIMBER-X is computationally efficient enough to permit multi-millennial integrations, making it well-suited for exploring the state space through moderately sized perturbation ensembles.

We first equilibrate CLIMBER-X at 15 prescribed atmospheric CO_2 concentrations between 285 and 600 ppm. Each equilibrium run is integrated for up to 20 000 model

years from the default pre-industrial restart. After equilibration, the trailing 500 years of the annual ocean time series are used to store reference values for AMOC strength at 26°N and for the salinity diagnostics in the geographical boxes illustrated in Fig. 1.

The North Atlantic box comprises Atlantic-basin grid cells from 35°–80°N and the Tropical Atlantic box comprises Atlantic-basin cells from 35°S–35°N. Both boxes cover the upper 105 m, corresponding to the top four ocean layers. The North and Tropical box perturbations use a two-grid-cell latitudinal taper and a two-layer vertical cosine taper. The tapered fields are normalised so that the volume-weighted mean anomaly over the hard target box remains exactly equal to the prescribed salinity perturbation. The salt added to the two Atlantic boxes is compensated uniformly over the rest of the world ocean within the same upper 105 m, so that the global ocean salt content in the restart is conserved.

For our experiments, we apply instantaneous salinity perturbations to these boxes directly to the ocean restart as salinity anomalies in psu, creating an ensemble of modified initial conditions. The North Atlantic and Tropical Atlantic perturbations each take the values $-2, -1.5, \ldots, 2$ psu, giving a 9×9 grid of 81 experiments per CO_2 level. Each perturbed initial condition is integrated forward for 10 000 model years. This model is known to exhibit an AMOC off-state under high CO_2 concentrations when large constant freshwater forcing in the North Atlantic is applied. In the present setup of pure initial salinity perturbations, the off-state is not reached. Instead, at higher CO_2 a second, distinct attractor with a somewhat stronger AMOC emerges. This occurs when sea ice in the Northern Hemisphere retreats and the deep-water convection driving the AMOC expands into areas farther north (**?**). We classify each grid trajectory by its final state using the same criterion as for the Boussinesq model: a run is assigned to the on-state if its final salinities lie within an $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu ball of the unperturbed reference state, and to the "strong" state otherwise.

A further CO_2-dependence concerns the long equilibration run itself: the state on which it settles, and which serves as the unperturbed reference, changes branch with forcing. Up to 330 ppm it lies on the reference ("modern") branch, whereas from 345 ppm

onward it lies on the stronger-AMOC ("strong") branch. The resilience measures obtained from the perturbation experiments are therefore associated with the modern state at 285–330 ppm and with the strong state at 345–600 ppm. The basin volume reported for CLIMBER-X (Table 1) is the share of the 81 grid trajectories that return to this reference equilibrium. It equals one wherever all perturbations recover and falls below one only near the modern-branch transition (at 315 and 330 ppm), where a fraction of perturbations settle on the strong state instead. From the same grid, we obtain the minimal critical shock as the smallest salinity-plane distance from the reference equilibrium to a perturbed initial condition that does not return to its basin. It is defined only where at least one perturbation escapes, i.e. at 315 and 330 ppm, since at all other CO_2 levels the entire ± 2 psu grid recovers. Figure 4 shows four example trajectories starting from perturbed salinity initial conditions in the specified boxes, similar to the two figures above. For both CO_2 values, the equilibrium states are the modern state.

To estimate local linear stability, we run a second, smaller ensemble of 9 experiments per CO_2 level. Eight runs apply isotropic salinity perturbations of magnitude $\varepsilon = 0.1$ psu again arranged on a circle in the two-dimensional (NA, Tropical) shallow-box salinity space, plus one unperturbed reference run. Each run is integrated for 500 model years. An equilibrium reference is obtained from the mean of the unperturbed run over years 10–150. A 2×2 discrete linear map is fitted by least squares to annual trajectory pairs (x_t, x_{t+1}) in the same fitting window. The continuous-time generator $A = \log(M)/(1\,\mathrm{yr})$ yields eigenvalues whose least stable real part gives the local resilience $-\mathrm{Re}(\lambda_{\max})$.

2.4 PlaSim-LSG

The last component of the hierarchy is the coupled climate model of intermediate complexity PlaSim-LSG, comprising a spectral primitive-equation atmosphere (T21, $\approx 5.6^\circ \times 5.6^\circ$, 10 vertical levels) and the Large Scale Geostrophic (LSG) ocean (Maier-Reimer et al., 1993), a full 3-D ocean circulation model at $3.5^\circ \times 3.5^\circ$ resolution with 22 vertical levels, coupled to a thermodynamic sea-ice scheme and a hydrological cycle. With approximately 10^5 degrees of freedom and a throughput of roughly 700 model years per CPU

day, PlaSim-LSG is considerably more complex than CLIMBER-X. In particular, it resolves atmospheric variability more faithfully and thereby yields seemingly chaotic ocean dynamics.

At 285 ppm (pre-industrial) and 360 ppm (contemporary) CO_2, PlaSim-LSG exhibits a bistable AMOC with an on-state of ≈ 15 Sv and an off-state (deep convection in Subpolar Gyre ceases) of $\approx 1-2$ Sv, both confirmed by long unforced simulations. Börner et al. (2026) applied an edge-tracking algorithm (Lucarini and Bódai, 2017) to locate the edge state (Melancholia state) of the AMOC in PlaSim-LSG at 285 ppm and 360 ppm. This is a quasi-stable equilibrium on the complex basin boundary between the on and off states. The algorithm iteratively bisects pairs of trajectories converging to opposite attractors and tracks the resulting pseudotrajectory along the basin boundary until it converges to the edge state. The edge state is a chaotic saddle characterised by persistent centennial AMOC oscillations (≈ 120 yr period, amplitude 3–10 Sv), driven by atmosphere–ice–ocean interactions in the North Atlantic. A complete description of the model configuration, its AMOC bistability, and the edge-tracking procedure is given in Börner et al. (2026), to which we refer the reader for full methodological details.

From the final iterations of edge tracking at each CO_2 level, we extract pairs of edge tracks: one converging to the on-state and one converging to the off-state, both initialised from near-boundary conditions that closely shadow the edge state before diverging. These trajectories provide a natural set of initial conditions from which resilience-relevant transient behaviour can be quantified: they start close to the basin boundary and thus represent challenging recovery paths for the on-state. In total, we analyse 37 paired edge-track files at 285 ppm and 38 at 360 ppm. Dedicated long equilibrium simulations of the AMOC-on, AMOC-off, and edge states at each CO_2 level provide the attractor clouds against which these transients are evaluated.

We reduce the high-dimensional PlaSim-LSG salinity output to the salinity of two geographical boxes. The North Atlantic readout is the mean salinity from 35°–80°N and 0–1000 m depth, and the Tropical Atlantic readout covers 35°S–35°N and 0–500 m depth. Dedicated on-, off-, and edge-state equilibria trajectories determine the means associated

with these states in this two-dimensional salinity plane. The covariance matrices of the scattered trajectory points are computed to obtain an approximate Gaussian distribution of data for each state. Convergence time is measured from the last visit to the edge-state 4σ Gaussian ellipse to the first entry into the target-attractor ellipse, and the critical-shock proxy is the gap between the edge-state and on-state ellipses, measured along the line joining their centres. Local resilience is quantified as the inverse width of the on-state fluctuation cloud, $[2000\sqrt{\lambda_{\max}(C)}]^{-1}$, where $\lambda_{\max}(C)$ is the largest eigenvalue of the on-state equilibrium covariance C. A broader cloud, i.e. larger salinity fluctuations around the on-state, corresponds to lower local resilience since the system appears less capable of absorbing internal variability.

3 Results

The trajectories from the described perturbation experiments are synthesised to give resilience estimates according to all measures listed in Table 1. The evolution of the resilience measures is shown in Figure 6, which forms the basis for the subsequent comparison and differentiation of the results. The models differ substantially in the dynamical characteristics of the AMOC, including its stationarity, multistability, and bifurcations. This, in itself, complicates the interpretation of our results on AMOC resilience within a common framework.

The models do not agree on a consistent impact of atmospheric CO_2 on the equilibrium AMOC strength. The 3-box model exhibits AMOC weakening, which is consistent with behaviour exhibited by the FAMOUS Earth System Model (**?**), the calibration target for the 3-box model (Alkhayuon et al., 2019). The vanishing of the AMOC on-state in a bifurcation at a threshold CO_2 concentration has, on the other hand, not been observed in FAMOUS. In the Boussinesq model, CLIMBER-X, and PlaSim-LSG, AMOC strength increases as the CO_2 concentration rises. For the latter two models, it has been conjectured that this is due to a changing net surface freshwater flux, particularly in the Tropical Atlantic (**?**). More evaporation implies more saline water reaching the North Atlantic. Abstracting this mechanism could provide insight into the same phenomenon

in the Boussinesq model. Because the surface freshwater forcing weakens in the central (tropical) part of the model relative to the right (northern) part, the salt-advection feedback might weaken as a response to the implicit CO_2 forcing. None of the three models exhibits a vanishing AMOC on-state in a bifurcation.

The existence and characteristics of an AMOC off-state are also not consistent across the model hierarchy. The 3-box and Boussinesq models feature stable states with reversed AMOC flow. That is, the salinity gradient between the North and Tropical Atlantic reverses in both models, and in the Boussinesq model, the actual fluid overturning changes direction. It is unclear whether this is physically meaningful behaviour, i.e. whether any real-world AMOC collapse would lead to a strong reversed flow. However, as we regard alternative stable states primarily as differentiations from the contemporary AMOC state, their exact characteristics are of little concern. The PlaSim-LSG model exhibits an AMOC off-state characterised by a breakdown of deep-water convection in the North Atlantic. The CLIMBER-X model exhibits a weak AMOC state only at CO_2 concentrations lower than preindustrial conditions. This is due to more extensive North Atlantic sea ice blocking deep-water convection in the Labrador and Irminger Seas. The only relevant alternative state for our experiments is a stronger AMOC state at large CO_2 concentrations, reached when diminished Northern sea ice allows for additional deep-water convection in the Kara Sea and Nansen Basin (**?**). It is important to consider these differences, especially when interpreting the results of basin volume and minimal critical shock. The two measures should only be interpreted as resilience against AMOC collapse when the alternative state is indeed associated with an AMOC weakening.

Local resilience of the on-state describes the restoring force that returns small perturbations back to the equilibrium. It can be interpreted as an upper bound on the reciprocal of the half-life of any small perturbation. Critical slowing-down theory predicts a decrease in local resilience as one approaches a bifurcation tipping point. This is indeed what we see for the 3-box model. Local resilience of the Boussinesq and CLIMBER-X AMOC also seems to decrease with increasing CO_2, though the decrease is less pronounced and accompanied by fluctuations in the latter case. In the PlaSim-LSG model, the trajectory

cloud forming the quasistationary on-state equilibrium slightly decreases in size, which is consistent with a larger local Lyapunov exponent and, thereby, stronger local resilience.

The convergence time aggregates show consistent trends as CO_2 forcing increases. In all models, the mean time needed for a probed perturbation to converge back to the on-state increases. This can be interpreted as a loss of resilience, as the AMOC is outside its usual operating regime for longer. One model-specific behaviour is worth emphasising in this context. The transient trajectories of some perturbations in the CLIMBER-X model at 315ppm show long occupancy of the strong AMOC state before eventually converging to the modern state (see SI Figure S1). It is possible that all perturbations marked as converging to the strong state in the 10,000 years of trajectory integration would eventually return to the modern state. Under the 330ppm configuration, these long transients remain in the strong state basin for the entire 10ky, reducing the estimated basin volume of the modern state and the mean convergence time. Whether this, too, constitutes spurious meta-stability cannot be determined with these experiments. This highlights the limitations in the numerical computation of resilience measures and the need to accurately define a finite-time framework for their interpretation. Throughout this study, convergence is never determined analytically but obtained via a finite-time cutoff evaluation against a neighbourhood convergence criterion (Morr et al., 2026).

A less intuitive result emerges from the basin volume computations. The share of initial perturbations in the region spanned by ± 2 psu in Northern and Tropical salinity that converge to the on-state rises in the 3-box and Boussinesq model when CO_2 increases. This is surprising insofar as it indicates a strengthening of the AMOC's resilience in this interpretation. Only in the immediate proximity to the bifurcation threshold of the 3-box model do we see a sharp decrease in basin volume. The basin structure of the CLIMBER-X model is almost trivial. For most considered CO_2 concentrations, all probed perturbations converge to either the modern AMOC on-state (300ppm and below) or the emerging strong AMOC state (345ppm onwards). Only at 315 ppm and 330 ppm do perturbations of the modern state lead to a transient convergence to the strong state, splitting the basin.

Finally, the minimal critical shock shows a consistent increase in the 3-box, Boussinesq,

and PlaSim-LSG models. In CLIMBER-X, it is only defined at 315 and 330 ppm, where it decreases as the strong state takes over a growing part of the probed region. The increase in the other three models would mean an increase in resilience, as larger perturbations are needed to push the AMOC to divergence away from the on-state.

4 Discussion

The picture emerging from our multi-model, multi-measure comparison of AMOC resilience is ambiguous. It is confounded by challenges in conceptual compatibility and practical differences in dynamical characteristics. Some measures exhibit internal inconsistencies in resilience trends across models. Other measures show a consistent increase in resilience, which seems incompatible with a consistent decrease in resilience on another measure. The notion of a real-world AMOC at risk of bifurcation tipping due to anthropogenic influences suggests a decrease in all resilience measures discussed near the bifurcation point (Morr et al., 2026). The simple bifurcating 3-box model does produce a decrease in basin volume and minimal critical shock, but only as it enters the direct proximity of the bifurcation, and the on-state basin contracts to a smaller size than the ± 2 psu salinity region.

The moderate decrease in local resilience observed in the Boussinesq and CLIMBER-X models reinforces the notion that critical slowing down should be expected prior to a bifurcation-mediated AMOC collapse. However, these quantities are obtained in equilibrium, and the real-world AMOC is likely still adapting to fast anthropogenic influences. The direct implications for the applicability of CSD-based early warning signals, therefore, remain limited. In addition, the PlaSim-LSG result suggests a strengthening of local resilience through a reduction in the stationary variance of the quasi-equilibrium state. The consistent increase in non-local convergence time could be interpreted as indicating that the change in the local restoring force generalises to larger regions of the basins of attraction. It lends further credence to the notion of critical slowing down, even as the local radius of perturbations is extended.

Basin volume, as we have computed it here, provides insight into how the on-state

provenance evolves under the chosen perturbation regime. For the Boussinesq model, the increase is moderate, as in fact only 31 out of 400 perturbation runs switch their basin membership between 280 and 643 ppm, all of them from the off- to the on-state basin. The contraction of the modern state basin in the CLIMBER-X model reveals novel insights into Earth System Model dynamics. To our knowledge, this is the first instance of a model of this size exhibiting bistability with respect to changes in the initial salinity configuration. Typically, modelling studies employ persistent hosing influences to permanently alter surface salinity and facilitate an AMOC collapse. The possibility that pulse perturbations could similarly lead to the convergence to an alternative stable state, albeit a stronger one, should inspire future research.

The minimal critical shock provides context for the results on basin volume, since the two are mechanistically related. It reveals that the increase in basin volume is at least in part mediated by an expansion of the basin boundary at the point where it is closest to the on-state. This point is a natural candidate for the so-called instanton path to pass through (**??**). This is the most likely path in which a random transition occurs when forced by small noise. It is also related to saddle points or edge states, which are unstable equilibrium points on the boundary (Lucarini and Bódai, 2017; **?**). The result of the PlaSim-LSG model is consistent with the interpretation of a distancing saddle point on the basin boundary of the 3-box and Boussinesq model. This is because, in this case, we are measuring the distance between the on-state and the edge state, which was directly approximated using an edge-tracking algorithm (Börner et al., 2026). The consistent increase in minimal critical shock should be studied in a broader selection of models going forward, as it reveals important information about the most likely transition path in an AMOC collapse.

Our comparative study of AMOC resilience does not offer concrete physical insight into AMOC dynamics. However, the discrepancies and consistent behaviours found across measures and models inspire a more careful selection of these measures and models. In principle, the evolution of resilience measures could provide valuable insight into the mechanistic changes the AMOC undergoes under climate change. It is not a priori expected

that simple models exhibit the same resilience behaviour as complex models, and none may represent the true AMOC dynamics well enough to allow generalisation of our findings in any sense. Our findings offer a first insight into whether and how resilience can be consistently defined and computed across models of varying complexity. Experiments with higher-fidelity models may help resolve some of the discrepancies that arose here. If the real-world AMOC is indeed approaching a bifurcation threshold, we expect insights from the simple 3-box model to be valuable, as many current climate models struggle to reproduce this threshold (**???**). On the other hand, results from simple models should be regarded with caution and treated as strong abstractions.

We hope to inspire future research on the AMOC and other natural systems under the framework of dynamical system resilience. Its system-agnostic nature enables effective comparison of system dynamics, while questions remain about its consistent adaptability across model hierarchies.

References

Alkhayuon, H., Ashwin, P., Jackson, L. C., Quinn, C., and Wood, R. A. (2019). Basin bifurcations, oscillatory instability and rate-induced thresholds for Atlantic meridional overturning circulation in a global oceanic box model. *Proceedings of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences*, 475(2225).

Armstrong McKay, D. I., Staal, A., Abrams, J. F., Winkelmann, R., Sakschewski, B., Loriani, S., Fetzer, I., Cornell, S. E., Rockström, J., and Lenton, T. M. (2022). Exceeding 1.5°C global warming could trigger multiple climate tipping points. *Science*, 377(6611):eabn7950.

Arnoldi, J.-F., Loreau, M., and Haegeman, B. (2016). Resilience, reactivity and variability: A mathematical comparison of ecological stability measures. *Journal of Theoretical Biology*, 389:47–59.

Ashwin, P., Wieczorek, S., Vitolo, R., and Cox, P. (2012). Tipping points in open systems: bifurcation, noise-induced and rate-dependent examples in the climate system. *Philo-*

sophical Transactions of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences, 370(1962):1166–1184.

Boers, N. (2021). Observation-based early-warning signals for a collapse of the Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation. *Nature Climate Change*, 11(8):680–688.

Bouttes, N., Good, P., Gregory, J. M., and Lowe, J. A. (2015). Nonlinearity of ocean heat uptake during warming and cooling in the FAMOUS climate model. *Geophysical Research Letters*, 42(7):2409–2416.

Börner, R., Mehling, O., Von Hardenberg, J., and Lucarini, V. (2026). Global stability of the Atlantic overturning circulation: edge state, long transients and boundary crisis under CO2 forcing. *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences*, 384(2322):20250087.

Cimatoribus, A. A., Drijfhout, S. S., and Dijkstra, H. A. (2014). Meridional overturning circulation: stability and ocean feedbacks in a box model. *Climate Dynamics*, 42(1-2):311–328.

Clark, P. U., Pisias, N. G., Stocker, T. F., and Weaver, A. J. (2002). The role of the thermohaline circulation in abrupt climate change. *Nature*, 415(6874):863–869.

Dakos, V., Scheffer, M., van Nes, E. H., Brovkin, V., Petoukhov, V., and Held, H. (2008). Slowing down as an early warning signal for abrupt climate change. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 105(38):14308–14312.

Dansgaard, W., Johnsen, S., Clausen, H., Dahl-Jensen, D., Gundestrup, N., Hammer, C., and Oeschger, H. (1984). North Atlantic climatic oscillations revealed by deep Greenland ice cores. In Hansen, J. E. and Takahashi, T., editors, *Geophysical Monograph Series*, volume 29, pages 288–298. American Geophysical Union, Washington, D. C.

Datseris, G., Luiz Rossi, K., and Wagemakers, A. (2023). Framework for global stability analysis of dynamical systems. *Chaos: An Interdisciplinary Journal of Nonlinear Science*, 33(7):073151.

Dijkstra, H. A. and Molemaker, M. J. (1997). Symmetry breaking and overturning oscillations in thermohaline-driven flows. *Journal of Fluid Mechanics*, 331:169–198.

Ditlevsen, P. and Ditlevsen, S. (2023). Warning of a forthcoming collapse of the Atlantic meridional overturning circulation. *Nature Communications*, 14(1):4254.

Esclapez, L., Jacques-Dumas, V., Börner, R., Soucasse, L., and Dijkstra, H. A. (2026). Constructing efficient score functions for rare event simulation in high-dimensional ocean-climate models. Version Number: 1.

Ganachaud, A. and Wunsch, C. (2000). Improved estimates of global ocean circulation, heat transport and mixing from hydrographic data. *Nature*, 408(6811):453–457.

Gunderson, L. H. (2000). Ecological Resilience—In Theory and Application. *Annual Review of Ecology and Systematics*, 31(1):425–439.

Halekotte, L. and Feudel, U. (2020). Minimal fatal shocks in multistable complex networks. *Scientific Reports*, 10(1):11783.

Held, H. and Kleinen, T. (2004). Detection of climate system bifurcations by degenerate fingerprinting. *Geophysical Research Letters*, 31(23).

Holling, C. S. (1973). Resilience and Stability of Ecological Systems. *Annual Review of Ecology and Systematics*, 4(1):1–23.

Jackson, L. C., Kahana, R., Graham, T., Ringer, M. A., Woollings, T., Mecking, J. V., and Wood, R. A. (2015). Global and European climate impacts of a slowdown of the AMOC in a high resolution GCM. *Climate Dynamics*, 45(11-12):3299–3316.

Jacques-Dumas, V., Dijkstra, H. A., and Kuehn, C. (2024). Resilience of the Atlantic meridional overturning circulation. *Chaos: An Interdisciplinary Journal of Nonlinear Science*, 34(12):123162.

Johns, W. E., Elipot, S., Smeed, D. A., Moat, B., King, B., Volkov, D. L., and Smith, R. H. (2023). Towards two decades of Atlantic Ocean mass and heat transports at

26.5° N. *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences*, 381(2262):20220188.

Khan, K. A. and Barton, P. I. (2015). A vector forward mode of automatic differentiation for generalized derivative evaluation. *Optimization Methods and Software*, 30(6):1185–1212.

Klinshov, V. V., Nekorkin, V. I., and Kurths, J. (2015). Stability threshold approach for complex dynamical systems. *New Journal of Physics*, 18(1):013004.

Krakovská, H., Kuehn, C., and Longo, I. P. (2024). Resilience of dynamical systems. *European Journal of Applied Mathematics*, 35(1):155–200.

Lenton, T. M. (2011). Early warning of climate tipping points. *Nature Climate Change*, 1(4):201–209.

Lohmann, J. and Ditlevsen, P. D. (2021). Risk of tipping the overturning circulation due to increasing rates of ice melt. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 118(9):e2017989118.

Lohmann, J., Hansen, A. B., Lovo, A., Chapman, R., Bouchet, F., and Lucarini, V. (2025). The role of edge states for early warning of tipping points. *Proceedings of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences*, 481(2312):20240753.

Lucarini, V. and Bódai, T. (2017). Edge states in the climate system: exploring global instabilities and critical transitions. *Nonlinearity*, 30(7):R32–R66.

Maier-Reimer, E., Mikolajewicz, U., and Hasselmann, K. (1993). Mean Circulation of the Hamburg LSG OGCM and Its Sensitivity to the Thermohaline Surface Forcing. *Journal of Physical Oceanography*, 23(4):731–757.

McCarthy, G. D. and Caesar, L. (2023). Can we trust projections of AMOC weakening based on climate models that cannot reproduce the past? *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences*, 381(2262):20220193.

561 Menck, P. J., Heitzig, J., Marwan, N., and Kurths, J. (2013). How basin stability com-
562 plements the linear-stability paradigm. *Nature Physics*, 9(2):89–92.

563 Menviel, L. C., Skinner, L. C., Tarasov, L., and Tzedakis, P. C. (2020). An ice–climate
564 oscillatory framework for Dansgaard–Oeschger cycles. *Nature Reviews Earth & Envi-*
565 *ronment*, 1(12):677–693.

566 Morr, A., Kuehn, C., and Datseris, G. (2026). Computing resilience measures in dynamical
567 systems. *Chaos: An Interdisciplinary Journal of Nonlinear Science*, 36(2):023102.

568 Neubert, M. G. and Caswell, H. (1997). Alternatives to Resilience for Measuring the
569 Responses of Ecological Systems to Perturbations. *Ecology*, 78(3):653.

570 Rahmstorf, S., Crucifix, M., Ganopolski, A., Goosse, H., Kamenkovich, I., Knutti, R.,
571 Lohmann, G., Marsh, R., Mysak, L. A., Wang, Z., and Weaver, A. J. (2005). Thermo-
572 haline circulation hysteresis: A model intercomparison. *Geophysical Research Letters*,
573 32(23):L23605.

574 Schaumann, F. and Alastrué de Asenjo, E. (2025). Weakening AMOC reduces ocean
575 carbon uptake and increases the social cost of carbon. *Proceedings of the National*
576 *Academy of Sciences*, 122(9):e2419543122.

577 Scheffer, M., Bascompte, J., Brock, W. A., Brovkin, V., Carpenter, S. R., Dakos, V.,
578 Held, H., van Nes, E. H., Rietkerk, M., and Sugihara, G. (2009). Early-warning signals
579 for critical transitions. *Nature*, 461(7260):53–59.

580 Schneider, T., Lan, S., Stuart, A., and Teixeira, J. (2017). Earth System Modeling 2.0:
581 A Blueprint for Models That Learn From Observations and Targeted High-Resolution
582 Simulations. *Geophysical Research Letters*, 44(24).

583 Stouffer, R. J., Yin, J., Gregory, J. M., Dixon, K. W., Spelman, M. J., Hurlin, W., Weaver,
584 A. J., Eby, M., Flato, G. M., Hasumi, H., Hu, A., Jungclaus, J. H., Kamenkovich, I. V.,
585 Levermann, A., Montoya, M., Murakami, S., Nawrath, S., Oka, A., Peltier, W. R.,
586 Robitaille, D. Y., Sokolov, A., Vettoretti, G., and Weber, S. L. (2006). Investigating

the Causes of the Response of the Thermohaline Circulation to Past and Future Climate Changes. *Journal of Climate*, 19(8):1365–1387.

Talley, L. D., Reid, J. L., and Robbins, P. E. (2003). Data-Based Meridional Overturning Streamfunctions for the Global Ocean. *Journal of Climate*, 16(19):3213–3226.

Valdes, P. (2011). Built for stability. *Nature Geoscience*, 4(7):414–416.

van Westen, R. M., Kliphuis, M., and Dijkstra, H. A. (2024). Physics-based early warning signal shows that AMOC is on tipping course. *Science Advances*, 10(6):eadk1189.

van Westen, R. M., Vanderborght, E., and Dijkstra, H. A. (2025). A saddle-node bifurcation may be causing the AMOC collapse in the Community Earth System Model. *Earth System Dynamics*, 16(6):2063–2085.

Willeit, M. and Ganopolski, A. (2024). Generalized stability landscape of the Atlantic meridional overturning circulation. *Earth System Dynamics*, 15(6):1417–1434.

Willeit, M., Ganopolski, A., Robinson, A., and Edwards, N. R. (2022). The Earth system model CLIMBER-X v1.0 – Part 1: Climate model description and validation. *Geoscientific Model Development*, 15(14):5905–5948.

Wood, R. A., Rodríguez, J. M., Smith, R. S., Jackson, L. C., and Hawkins, E. (2019). Observable, low-order dynamical controls on thresholds of the Atlantic meridional overturning circulation. *Climate Dynamics*, 53(11):6815–6834.

Yang, Q., Dixon, T. H., Myers, P. G., Bonin, J., Chambers, D., van den Broeke, M. R., Ribergaard, M. H., and Mortensen, J. (2016). Recent increases in Arctic freshwater flux affects Labrador Sea convection and Atlantic overturning circulation. *Nature Communications*, 7(1):10525.

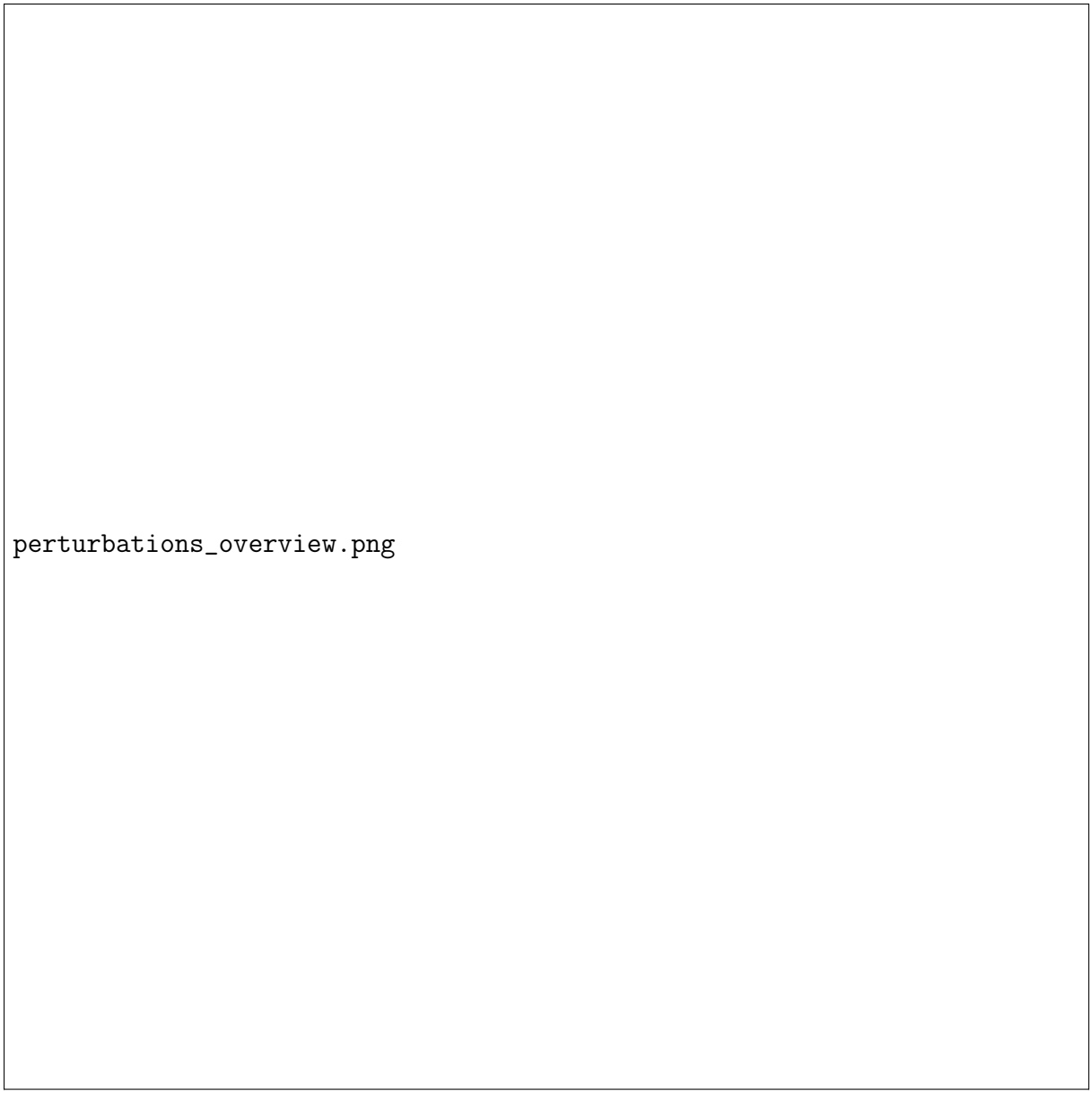


Figure 1: **Perturbation and read-out geometry across the model hierarchy.** This overview compares the geographic salinity regions used as perturbation coordinates (shaded regions) in the Boussinesq and CLIMBER-X experiments and as salinity read-outs (dashed boxes) in the Boussinesq, CLIMBER-X, and PlaSim-LSG analysis. The box geometry associated with the 3-box model is approximately reproduced from the model conception in Wood et al. (2019).



Figure 2: **Three-box model response to salinity perturbations.** Top panels (a, b) show the evolution of the AMOC strength for four representative initial conditions, with dashed horizontal lines marking the on- and off-state equilibria. Bottom panels (c, d) show the same trajectories in the two-dimensional salinity state space (the two state variables), overlaid on the sampled basins of attraction; circles represent 0.05 psu neighbourhoods around the on- and off-state fixed points (blue and orange, respectively). The left and right columns correspond to 280 and 448 ppm model specifications, respectively.



Figure 3: **Boussinesq model response to salinity perturbations.** Top panels (a, b) show the evolution of the AMOC strength for four representative initial conditions (the first 50 years of initial adjustment are omitted), with dashed horizontal lines marking the on- and off-state equilibria. Bottom panels (c, d) show the same trajectories in North Atlantic and Tropical Atlantic box-mean salinity, overlaid on the sampled basins of attraction. Circles represent 0.05 psu neighbourhoods around the on- and off-state fixed points (blue and orange, respectively). Trajectories end once they enter one of these neighbourhoods, which can happen before the AMOC strength has fully adjusted. The left and right columns correspond to 280 and 488 ppm model specifications, respectively.



Figure 4: **CLIMBER-X model response to salinity perturbations.** Top panels (a, b) show the AMOC strength at 26°N along four example trajectories from perturbed salinity initial conditions. Bottom panels (c, d) show the same trajectories in the two-dimensional Atlantic-box salinity plane, with axes spanning exactly the ±2 psu perturbation window. The shaded background maps the basin of attraction of every initial condition on the full 9×9 grid: cells whose trajectory returns to the reference on-state (final salinity within $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu) are blue, and cells that settle on the distinct stronger-AMOC ("strong") state are purple. Circles mark the $\varepsilon = 0.05$ psu neighbourhoods of the on-state (blue, at the unperturbed equilibrium) and of the strong state (purple, at the mean endpoint of the non-converged trajectories). The two columns show prescribed atmospheric CO_2 concentrations of 285 ppm and 330 ppm: at 285 ppm all 81 initial conditions return to the on-state, whereas at 330 ppm 46 of the 81 converge to the strong state, which lies only ≈0.08 psu from the on-state but exhibits an AMOC about 0.4 Sv stronger. Dashed horizontal lines in (a, b) mark the equilibrium AMOC strength of the on-state (blue) and, in (b), of the strong state (purple).

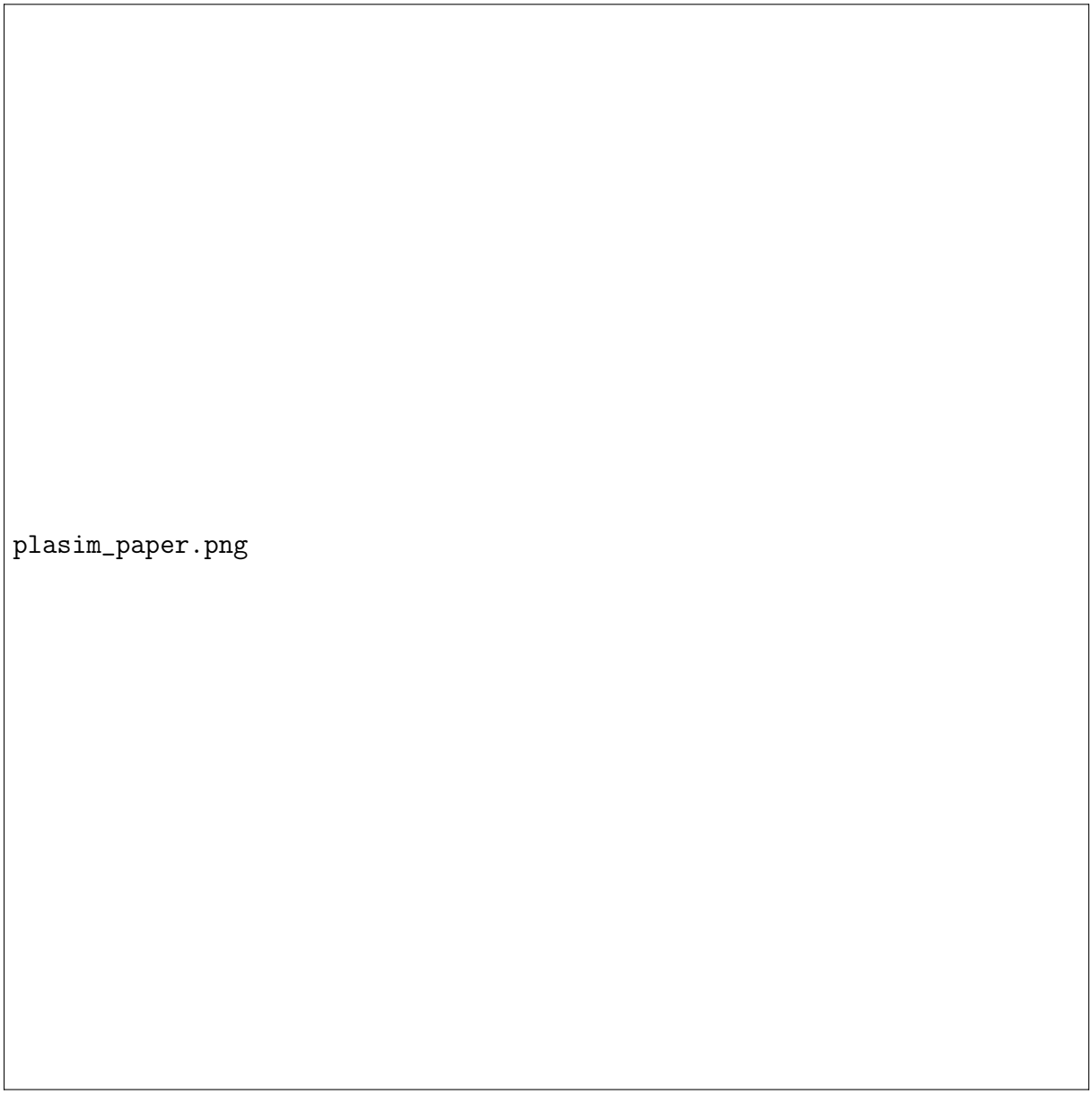


Figure 5: **PlaSim-LSG edge-state trajectories and covariance ellipses of attractors.** Top panels (a, b) show the AMOC strength readout along converged edge-track trajectories. Bottom panels (c, d) show the same transients in the North and Tropical Atlantic salinity coordinates. Ellipses denote the fitted 4σ Gaussian regions to equilibrium runs of the three states (on: blue, off: orange, edge: black), used to define convergence times and edge-to-attractor distances. Trajectories are coloured by the state they converge to. The two columns show the experiment results at prescribed atmospheric CO_2 concentrations of 285 ppm and 360 ppm, respectively.

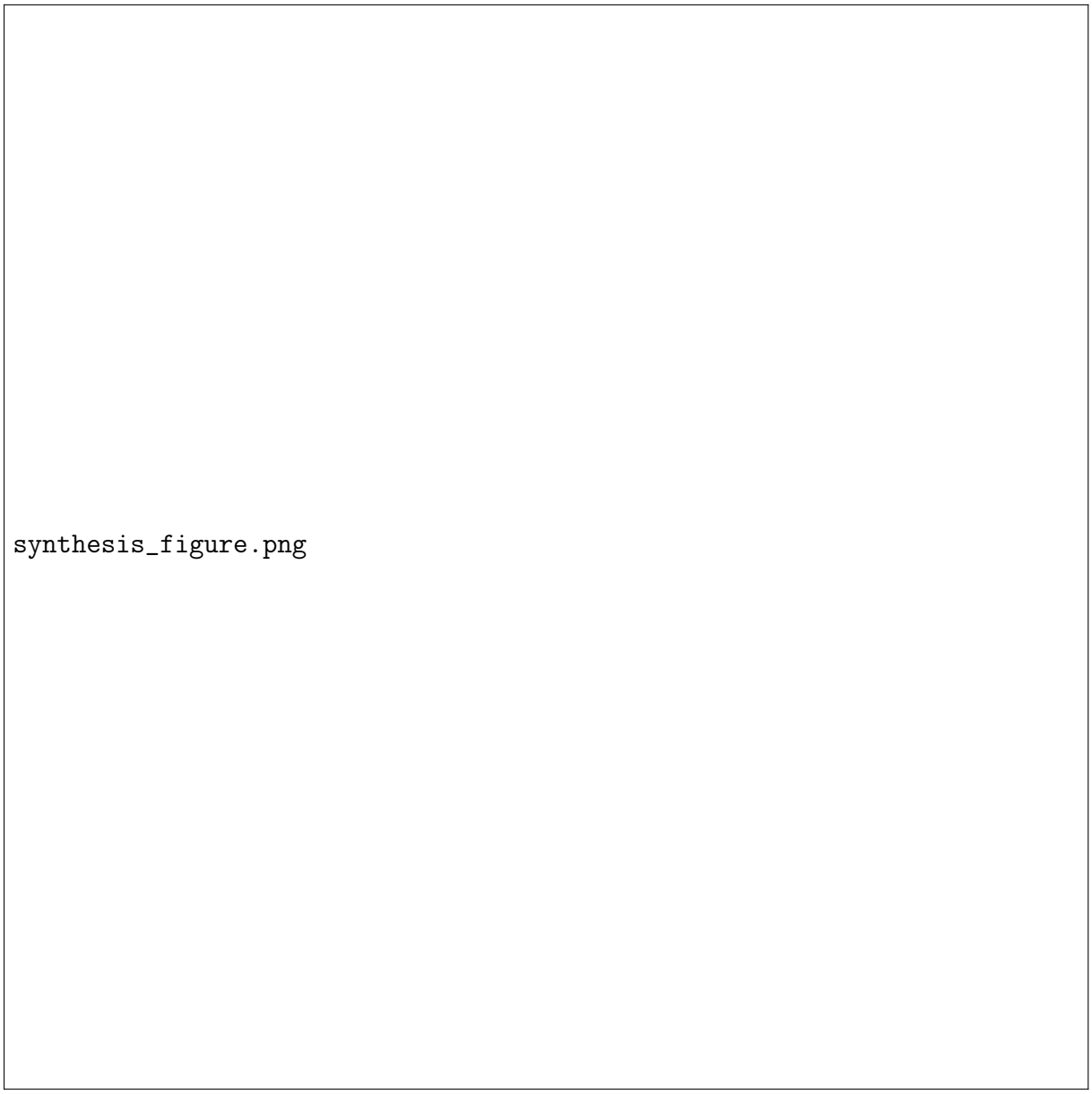


Figure 6: **Cross-model synthesis of AMOC resilience measures.** Equilibrium AMOC strength (a) and Tropical minus North Atlantic salinity gradient (b). Resilience quantifiers are plotted against the CO_2 coordinate for each model, where available (c–f). The model-specific definitions and implementation of each resilience quantifier are given in Table 1. These results provide the basis for assessing which resilience signals are coherent across the model hierarchy.